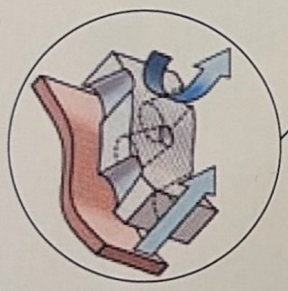
SUB-ZERO HERO

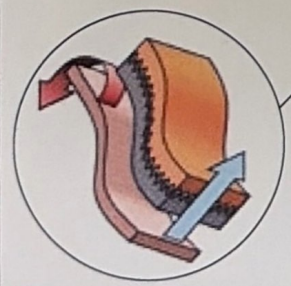
Cold War

Winter fabrics to keep you from making snow angels with the Grim Reaper.

Alaska is America's meat locker, and when the winter temperatures plummet to nut-calcifying lows (the state record is -79.8°F), back-country guides like Matt Szundy of the Ascending Path climbing service trust their shivering lives to designer fabrics. Follow his simple techwear guidelines or freeze to death on your way to the summit.

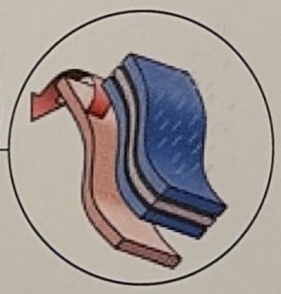


1 Base Layer
"Cotton kills" because it traps clammy moisture against your skin. Wool wicks this moisture away, but synthetic alternatives like Capilene can provide the same warmth with less bulk.



2 Insulating Layer
This layer goes directly over your base layer to slow down the loss of body heat. You'll want to retain as much freedom of movement as possible, so go with something nonrestrictive like a midweight polyester zip-up with Polartec. A good wool sweater will also do the trick, but venting can be tricky without a zipper.

3 Fleece Layer
Your tattered college hoodie gets soggy fast, and that paper-thin poncho in your closet lacks insulation. What to do? Bust out a Windstopper fleece, a sister product to Gore-Tex.



4 Outer Layer
Steer clear of the rubberized polyvinyls you find in cheap rain jackets. They may be waterproof, but they refuse to breathe. Instead, go with a Gore-Tex shell. This fabric has microscopic pores that keep external moisture out but allow water vapor (sweat) to escape.

Text, Jeff Foss

TEMP WORK

Mercury Falling

How cold is cold?

30°F: Chilly, but nothing an extra layer can't take care of.
29° to 15°: Cold. Now it's OK to complain about this fact.
14° to 0°: Damn cold, period.
-1° to -20°: Ass cold with frostbite possible. Go play indoors.
-21° to -60°: Downright brutal. Frostbite is more than likely.
-61° or lower: Obscenely frigid. Exposed flesh freezes in 30 seconds. Get off the mountain.

Illustration by **Benjamin Wachenje**

JAN EXP Style.F1.indd 1 11/2/06 5:46:09 PM